

Research Methods

Day 10 · Synthesizing Findings & Polishing the Middle

July 10, 2026

Welcome to Day 10!

Today you **synthesize** — turning a pile of results into a coherent story, and connecting it back to the literature.

By the end of the day you will be able to:

- **Synthesize** your results with existing literature into a coherent interpretation
- **Differentiate** results from discussion and conclusion
- **Strengthen** your methods and results sections
- Understand the role of **limitations** in scientific humility



"The Middle" of your paper is where data becomes meaning.



A finding only matters once you say **what it means** and **how it fits** what others have found.



Results vs. Discussion vs. Conclusion

Three Different Jobs

The biggest write-up confusion: blurring three sections that each do **one** job.

Results

What you found. Facts and numbers, no opinion. *"Group A scored 8 points higher ($p = 0.01$)."*

Discussion

What it means. Interpret, compare to the literature, explain, note limits. *"This aligns with Lee (2020)..."*

Conclusion

So what? The big-picture takeaway and why it matters. Short, no new data.

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Quick test: a sentence with a **number** is usually a *result*; a sentence with "**this suggests** / **because** / **compared to**" is usually *discussion*.

Spot the Section

Which section does each sentence belong in — **Results**, **Discussion**, or **Conclusion**?

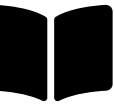
1. *"Students who slept more scored 6 points higher on average."*
2. *"This supports Garcia (2019), who linked sleep to memory consolidation."*
3. *"Schools should consider later start times to support learning."*

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1. *"Students who slept more scored 6 points higher on average."*
2. *"This supports Garcia (2019), who linked sleep to memory consolidation."*
3. *"Schools should consider later start times to support learning."*

1.  **Results** — a measured fact.
2.  **Discussion** — compares to the literature.
3.  **Conclusion** — the broader "so what."



Synthesizing Results with the Literature

What Does "Discuss" Actually Mean?

To **discuss** your findings is to do **five things, in order**:

- 1 **Restate** your key finding (in plain language).
- 2 **Compare** it to what the literature said — agree? disagree? extend?
- 3 **Explain** *why* you might have found what you found.
- 4 **Acknowledge** your limitations.
- 5 **Suggest** what comes next.

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This is the skeleton of **every** Discussion section you'll ever read. Master the order and the writing gets much easier.

Synthesis in Action

A worked Discussion mini-paragraph:

*"We found that students with more screen time slept about 1.3 hours less (**restate**). This echoes Twenge (2017), who reported the same link in a national sample (**compare**). A likely mechanism is delayed bedtime from late-night use (**explain**). Our sample was small and self-reported (**limitation**), so a larger study with objective sleep tracking is a natural next step (**next**)."*

Every finding earns a citation.

Each result in your Discussion should connect to **at least one source** from your literature review — agreement *or* tension both count.

Limitations: Scientific Humility

Naming limitations isn't weakness — it's **credibility**. It shows you understand what your study can and cannot claim.

Common, honest limitations:

- Small or non-random **sample**
- **Self-reported** or noisy measures
- **Observational** data → correlation, not proof of cause
- Short **time window**

Frame each limitation forward:

"Because our sample was one school, results may not generalize — a multi-school study would test this."

 A limitation **bounds** your claim; it doesn't erase it.



Your Turn: Work for the Rest of Class

What to Work On – Rest of Class

Work through these three tasks **as a team** for the remainder of class. I'll circulate – wave me over with questions.

1

Methods + Results presentations – each team presents its Methods & Results slides: **2 min present + 2 min feedback**. As audience, ask: results clear? figures interpretable? methods accurate? Give **one strength + one specific fix** ("the axis needs units," not "nice chart").

2

"Synthesizing Findings" Mission Sheet – four sentences: (1) main conclusion, (2) comparison to one source you agree/disagree with, (3) one limitation, (4) one next step. **Swap with a neighboring team** for feedback before finalizing.

3

Draft your Discussion & Conclusion slides – answer: What do our results **mean**? Did they **support or challenge** our hypothesis? Who should **care**? Add interpretation – don't just repeat the chart.

90:00